

“I don’t know much”

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Spring 2020

Professor Michael Jackson

Here is my knife, see. I'm going to place it between us while I tell you this story. It's what my grandmother did when talking with young people and it's what I'm going to do now. If you don't believe my story, you can use it on me. But I'll tell you what I can. I don't know much.

You could feel them before you see them. Their presence in the trees. You felt them on your skin, the way static runs across it, each hair on your arm standing at attention. The long grass shivered as our footsteps broke its wake, sending ripples that gossiped with the grove of trees, telling them of our arrival. The cottonwood leaves showed each visitor their silver bellies as they shook with a death rattle in a sudden breeze.

High up, forked branches supported the bundles. They were wrapped in red spirit cloth, encased in buffalo hide. I didn't know them. Unless it's winter, our family buried our lost ones in the ground, just past the grove. The moniyaw¹ children dared each other to get close to the burial ground, chasing and goading one another, their screeches carried away on the wind that never stills. I wished they would stay away. They didn't understand that a place can't be haunted. We are all haunted, everywhere. It's not a bad thing. Our ancestors never leave us.

The worst that might happen is that the bones get sassy. Mother told me a story about an angry moniyaw man called One-Pound-One. I think he was called that because he had a limp, but I didn't ask too many questions when she told stories, scared that she'd tell me *awas!* and send me out the door again. She said people danced when One-Pound-One died, they were so happy. They made an old Cree noosum² boil his bones so that they could move them east in a wagon. If everyone hated him so much, I'm not sure why they bothered. Even before the water

¹ Non-Indigenous

² One of our grandmothers

boiled, his bones hissed and crackled and made the water bubble, spitting and frothing with rage, just as he did when he was alive. After the bones were off on their jostling journey, the women chilled the pot outside in cold winter. In the morning, they lifted the fat off the top of the pot, melted it into water and lye, and made soap. Fat tears of laughter rolled down my mother's cheeks as she said this, imagining what dirty One-Pound-One would think of his bones being used to keep the Fort clean. I thought of those screeching children up to their elbows in soap and water on wash days and fat tears of laughter rolled down my face too.

I've never actually seen a living buffalo. It's strange, given that the spectre of the buffalo is everywhere – the huge rugs that cover the quarter sawn wood floors in our cabin, the covers that keep our small village of lodges waterproof, the soft moccasins on my feet, even rope woven from sinew. I've tasted them in pemmican, greasy and tart with powdered berries. The pemmican didn't take long to run out, though.

A long time ago, Creator sent a medicine stone called papamihaw asiniy – Flying Rock – to protect Grandmother Buffalo. Flying Rock came down from the sky, crashing into a hill between Cree and Blackfoot territory. At first, it was light enough to be picked up, but over the years, it grew and grew to be so heavy that no one could move it from its place. The face of Creator was etched into the dark stone, watching over the land in between the territories that was rich with berries, medicine, and buffalo. Up until then, the Cree and Blackfoot fought over this land, but they both knew that Flying Rock was sent as a reminder that no one can *own* the land or the buffalo – they are to be shared by all. Peace and abundance came to the hills around the stone. When hunters returned every year, they stopped at Flying Rock to give tobacco, offerings, and prayers.

When Flying Rock arrived, so did a prophecy. In order to protect Grandmother Buffalo and keep the peace, Flying Rock must never be moved. If it were ever moved, the prophecy stated that starvation, disease, and war would come. Not long before I was born, a missionary who was frustrated that he had no control over his “flock” during the hunting season, saw Flying Rock as a barrier to their conversion to Christianity. I don’t know how he managed it, but the missionary had the stone packed into an ox cart and moved it to his churchyard far away. That winter, the prophecy came true. Our people starved. Smallpox ran like prairie fire through our villages. The Cree and Blackfoot peoples went to war with one another.

Grandmother Buffalo had been travelling further and further away from Beaver Hills. Once Flying Rock disappeared, she wandered far into Blackfoot territory, and we followed her. Cree warriors attacked a Blood camp near Wetaskiwin. Wetaskiwin means “place of peace”. 300 men died. Of course, Uncle Tahkoots didn’t make things easier for our relationship. He was called “the Murderer” in town, a name he earned when he killed four Blackfoot in one year alone. One of the murders even triggered a Blackfoot attack on Edmonton House. The Hudson Bay Company tried to bribe Tahkoots to stop antagonizing the Blackfoot, but it never worked. He would take the money and do whatever he wanted anyway.

Despite the way Uncle Tahkoots did things, we were never meant to fight like that with our brothers and sisters. We used to create alliances during the hunting months. It is Grandmother Buffalo who chooses when and how and to whom she gives herself to, but we tried to control her gifts. Desperation caused us to turn our backs on these teachings. We were hungry, we were sick, and we were worried that we may not survive as a people. After the battle at Wetaskiwin, our spirits were even more bent.

“This much,” Uncle Papastayo would say, holding his rough brown hands about a foot apart. “That’s the deal, that’s all they can use.” For years after we signed the treaty, our nookums would ask him why we had to give up our way of life so that some woman, this Queen, could have our lands. They couldn’t respect a Mother Chief who didn’t come to them in person for ceremony and negotiation. I watched him from behind the knees of my mother and learned patience and respect, as again and again he explained that the only thing the moniyaw wanted was a foot of soil in certain spots so that they could farm. Where nothing grows, that will always be for us, he promised. Uncle didn’t talk about land ownership at that point – we didn’t know what that was yet. No one could own nature, the animals, plants, and dirt. Uncle agreed to shared custodianship and to share Creator’s gifts with the moniyaw. It was a peace treaty, he would explain. The nookums would eventually leave the cabin, murmuring to one another, until they came back a few sunsets later with the same questions. He would try and explain that just as Buffalo Spirit used to provide everything we need, the Mother Chief would provide. We had to fill the void that Grandmother Buffalo left behind or we would also wander back into the soil forever. The treaty meant never having to be hungry again, never worrying about how our children were to be clothed. And the price was a small one to pay! Just one foot of dirt. I think Uncle believed what he told them. He would never lie. But that didn’t protect them from the lies that he was told, that didn’t save them from the starvation that would overcome them when we found out that the promises made to our people were as empty as our bellies.

When my Uncle placed his X mark beside those of Chiefs Kiskicihcîs and Cacâstawaskam and their headmen, it probably looked like someone had spilled that canned soup with letters all over the paper. The people who said they spoke for the Mother Chief made promises that gave us hope, at time when we felt so hopeless. They told us that they would teach

us how to farm and give us tools and seeds to plant. We would be given cattle and they promised to help us if famine or disease came to our people. There would be no more need for war – we could provide for ourselves, and when we couldn't, the Mother would provide for us. We wouldn't have to travel into other territories in search for food and risk retaliation from our neighbours.

For a couple years after the treaty was signed, we had an Indian agent named Stewart. He was a decent man, agreed with Uncle that the reserve should be across the river from Fort Edmonton at Two Hills, and gave us as much rations as he could. He would sometimes come to the camp to talk to Uncle and Father. During those visits, he was exposed to the poverty of the people and learned of Mother Nature's abandonment. One summer he stopped coming and we found out that he had been cast off. It seemed that the government didn't approve of how much he had paid the Hudson's Bay Company for our rations and thought that him spending money on sugar and raisins for us was extravagant. I never saw any raisins.

One summer, I remember my father getting up just after dawn to meet Uncle. I could hear them murmuring to one another beside the riverbank, occasionally chuckling softly. They were watching the spot where the ferry cable stretched from shore to shore, waiting for the surveyors to cross the Swift Flowing River.³ On the south side of the river stood a two-story house, made out of logs and patched with mud. A Scotsman and his family lived there. They were called the Walters. They were one of the few moniyaw families on this side of the river. When the surveyors arrived on the north bank, they would ring a big bell that hung from a stake. Walter's man, McFadden, would stride out to the wooden ferry, light his pipe, and heave on the pulleys to bring the open-sided barge to the other bank. When they heard the bell, Father and Uncle began

³ North Saskatchewan River

the walk to the ferry landing, arriving in time to make sure the surveyors couldn't give them the slip. Uncle had chosen a reserve just south of where we had made camp and he was determined to make sure that he got every square mile that he had agreed to. It had been years since he had signed the treaty, and we still didn't have a reserve. We needed the reserve in order to farm, and we needed to farm in order to survive. The winter before, many of the Papaschase families had starved. All of the dogs in the camp had been killed for food and many of the horses. Some had to rely on the charity of the moniyaw at the Fort, and some women prostituted themselves, which brought great shame to Uncle and our people. Those who survived the winter could not have survived with any less than they did. We expected to be relieved by the spring and summer months, but they only brought more hunger. Mother Nature still hadn't returned since the Flying Rock was removed – there was no game, the berries were late, and even the fish seemed to stop swimming. We began to rely on rations from the Fort, but they were so meagre when shared between us all, it was only barely better than receiving nothing at all.

The afternoon of the day they went out with the surveyors, Father and Uncle burst into our lodge, arguing with one another angrily. "First they leave us to starve, then they refuse to pay us, and now they cheat us!" Uncle seethed. My Father tried to soothe him, but I could tell that he was just as angry. A few days earlier, when the Inspector had arrived at the Fort to pay us our treaty money, Uncle had refused to let anyone accept it until we were given proper food rations. He thought that he could force the Inspector to fulfill his promise of keeping our people from starvation, but his plan backfired. He underestimated their cruelty again. The Inspector left the Fort without giving rations or our money. Even worse, before he left, he rounded up all of our women and children that were begging in the Fort. He made a new band, which he called the "Edmonton Stragglers" and paid them their treaty money under that name instead of ours. While

Uncle was irritated that some of our people disobeyed his direction to refuse the annuities, and frustrated that we would have to wait until the Inspector came back to receive our treaty payments, he didn't realize the full ramifications of this until he had went trailing the surveyors that morning. It became obvious that the surveyors weren't giving us the amount of land for our reserve that was due. When Uncle started protesting in Cree, the surveyors responded in English, and everyone was thoroughly confused until Uncle sent Father to retrieve a translator from the Fort. By the time they had returned, Uncle had retraced every step they had made that day, pulling up the stakes the surveyors used to mark the boundaries of the new reserve. The translator told them that because the Inspector made a new band with the women and children found at the Fort, those people were no longer a part of our band, which means that we were entitled to less land than we had been the day before.

I never did find out exactly what words were said between the men after that, but I did feel sorry for the translator. Later that night, long after the adults had gotten into the drink, a runner knocked at the door with a message from the Indian Agent. The survey of the reserve would not be completed that year, if ever. I buried my head into my mother's chest that night as she covered us both with thick hides to drown out the noise, willing ourselves invisible.

We woke the next morning to even worse news, when we found out that another eighty-four members of our band joined the stragglers by taking their treaty money, which plummeted our numbers even further. Looking back, I can understand why they did it. Uncle was playing a risky game. Many of us had died from starvation over the last winter, and with scarce fish and game, there was no relief in sight. Uncle was relying on the belief that the government wouldn't let our lives be leverage. Not all of us could entertain that belief any longer, not what from what we had seen.

The next summer, the surveyors returned. This time Uncle could not afford to be so principled, and our reserve was staked, reduced as the Agents had seen fit. The winter before had not been merciful. By the time the Frost Moon had come, we had already been desperate. Disease returned to our lodges. Father took us far away from the camp and into Beaver Hills, which had sustained us in the past. He and my brothers hunted and trapped, coming home most days with tales of empty trap lines and barren horizons empty of game. My mother cried every morning as she dressed us, our protruding ribs and collarbones a harsh reminder of our desperation. One night I woke beside my sister Nancy, her tiny body frozen and stiff, her lips and fingernails blue as ice. She had not even seen her first birthday. We gave her a sky burial at White Mud Creek, with no sacred cloth with which to wrap her in. None of Manitou's creatures were there to hear our songs. The void swallowed them.

I don't remember playing with my brothers and sisters that winter. I don't remember listening to stories. I remember sleeping. I remember being so tired that my knees would shake when I stood. I remember how heavy my head felt when I lifted it to sip the broth which was all my mother had to offer. It tasted like warm water with a whisper of bones.

We tried that winter to seek help from the moniyaw. There was a provision in our treaty that clearly stated if we were facing starvation or disease, the Queen Mother would provide aid. There was famine. There was pestilence. There had been for years. There was no aid. Uncle, along with Chiefs Bobtail, Samson, and Ermineskin asked Father Scollen to write a letter to MacDonald. Despite their pride, they told MacDonald of our destitution and dire poverty, of how we weren't even supplied half of what we were promised – seed, farming tools, plows, cattle – and how our overseers had no sympathy for our condition.

We are reduced to the lowest stage of poverty. We were once a proud and independent people and now we are mendicants at the door of every white man in the country; and were it not for the charity of the white settlers

who are not bound by treaty to help us, we should all die on government fare. Our widows and old people are getting the barest pittance, just enough to keep body and soul together, and there have been cases in which body and soul have refused to stay together on such allowance. Our young women are reduced by starvation to become prostitutes to the white man for a living, a thing unheard of before amongst ourselves and always punishable by Indian law. What then are we to do?⁴

They told McDonald that if no attention was paid to them, they would conclude that the treaty they signed was completely empty and they instead meant to starve us out of existence. “If we must die by violence let us do it quickly.” Those were their words. That is one of our sayings. We knew we were dying, and there was no honour in that slow death. During the Goose Moon, we went on another desperate hunt. Along the way, carried on our mother’s back, my brother Charlie began to cough. By nightfall that day, he joined our sister in the spirit world. It became clear that the Chiefs were right, we were dying by violence and the war was dragging on. What stung the most, is that this violence targeted the weak and innocent, the children, widows, and our elders. If our children continued to die, there would be no future for our people. If our elders continued to die, there would be no past.

In the Moulting Moon, a delegate from Bear’s Hills arrived at Two Hills, passing through our camp beside the river on their way to the Fort. They told us that their people were in a similar state and they were determined to pay the Indian Agent a visit. Father, Uncle, and their friend Grasshopper decided to join them (thankfully, no one told Uncle Tahkoots about the opportunity for confrontation). They went to the Indian Agent and demanded more rations. The Agent told them that they knew better than to expect to be fed away from their reserves, and that he wouldn’t feed them even if he had food to give. This infuriated the delegation – if they could be fed on their reserves, they wouldn’t have gone there in the first place! Grasshopper ripped the Agent out of his chair and replaced him with Sam, his clerk. No translation was needed to

⁴ 7 January 1883, Fort Edmonton.

communicate that we wanted him out, and Sam in. The Agent continued to yell over the threats, telling them that there was no food to be had. Grasshopper spat, threw the Agent over his shoulder, and carried him like a sack all the way to the Hudson's Bay Company store. I'm not sure how they managed to work it out after that, except that the next day father took a cart to the store and loaded up provisions, and because of the deal we had to forgo our treaty payment that fall.

The agent, a wormy and fat man, was frantic after that. He asked for fifty North-West Mounted Police to come to the Fort to intimidate us. Clearly, the captain knew what a weak-willed man he was, because he only sent eight, who nonetheless they rushed to the Fort. When they got there, they found none of the calamity the agent had claimed – we were all back on our side of the river. They had to ask us to come back over so they could intimidate us. We decided to let them try. Father, Uncle, and Uncle Tahkoots dressed in full regalia, their faces and arms painted as if to go to war. They forded the river on the biggest war runners that we had, feathers and red cloth streaming from their tails and manes. I sat on the riverbank and listened to the echoing cracks from their guns and shrill shouts as they galloped the runners past our burial ground and up the hill, the bones of our ancestors vibrating beneath.

We were told that Uncle spoke well on behalf of the Beaver Hills and Bear's Hills people, and the police called an early halt to the discussion. The captain gave us another grant of provisions from the police's own stores before sending the delegation back across the river. Uncle Tahkoots, in a rare instance of restraint, quietly spread the word that if the police interfered the next time they confronted the agent, they better be ready for a real fight.

There was also a confrontation on Chief Poundmaker's reserve that summer, as well as an incident at Crooked Lakes, which meant that the Indian Agency's attitudes were being forced to shift.

Before the leaves began to turn, we held a thirst dance, and there was much excitement. We didn't hold them every year – they only happen when someone calls them because they have been faced with grave danger or challenge and promised to make an offering to Manitou if they survive it. The eldest daughter of one a band member called the Pound had become sick over the winter. Many times, mother was called to their lodge to tend to her, but somehow, she did not leave us. It was a long illness, lasting all through the winter and spring, and it was a miracle that she recovered. The Pound called a thirst dance in thanks to Manitou, where he would dance to honour the Thunderbird. Nehiyawak from all over came to join us, including from Egg Lake, Saddle Lake, Bear's Hills, and even further. Much to my uncle's dismay, thirteen young men from Big Bear's Band came too, led by Papastis. Uncle was worried about their attendance, as he knew they were seen as a troublemaking group, and the relationship with the Indian Agency had improved so much. Rumblings had been heard about trouble starting with Riel and his followers, which were tied to Big Bear. He couldn't risk being seen as in line with them for fear of another destitute winter. His worries were so great, in fact, that he was miserable the entire time the party was there, and followed the agent around making sure he knew that we weren't wasting our rations by dancing instead of working.

That didn't stop me from enjoying the event. There were about fifty tents there, and the chatter and music made my spirit soar in comparison to the grim silence that had so recently been settled over the reserve. It had felt like it would never break, but now I was running and chasing my friends and siblings, vibrant stories being told and made all around me.

There were many flesh offerings during this ceremony, more than I have ever seen before or since. All of the men, except those who were very old or children, fasted and separated themselves, under the strict guidance of the thirst dance chiefs. None of us could bring them water or food, they only consumed medicine from the thirst dance chief's hands themselves. The type of offering made by each dancer was based on the level of danger he and his family had faced. On one end of the range of offerings, a thirst dance chief would pierce the dancer's skin on his chest with a wooden peg and loop a long rawhide sling through the peg. The ends of the sling would be tied to the tree of life, which stands at the middle of the ceremony. The dancers would then run backwards as hard and fast as they could, throwing their weight back in hopes that the peg breaks through their skin. If they fail, they must return to the post and try again and again until they break free. Other dancers are pierced with a bigger peg on their shoulders, and the thick rawhide thong is attached to seven sacred objects (I had seen Uncle Tahkoots attach the thong to rifles before, too, but no doubt rifles are also sacred to him). These dancers must walk all the way around the thirst dance circle, dragging the objects. When they complete the circle, friends stand on the objects as the dancers run hard away from them, ripping the peg from their flesh. Finally, the greatest sacrifice is going to the centre pole. Great awls are pierced deeply into a dancer's chest, from which they are hung from the centre post until the thirst dance chief believes his pledge has been fulfilled. That year, Uncle Tahkoots and a young man from Big Bear's band called Tonguemaster went to the centre pole. Flapping their arms like great eagles, both men succeeded in breaking free before the Thirst Dance Chief called an end to the sacrifice, their bravery causing deep wounds on their chests, badges of honour that dripped blood all through the rest of the ceremony and the speeches that lasted through the night. Thunderbird was sure to be satisfied that their debt had been repaid in their suffering.

When it was time for the speeches, many of the men gave thanks that the Great Spirit surely walked with them through their troubles and appealed to the Indian Agents who gathered to witness the ceremonies. The Pound and Wapastaquan told the agents that they were poor now and wished that the moniyaw would show their affection by giving them something to eat. Shining Elbow made an appeal for them to give them money and provisions, so that the old and poor might also feast after the dance was over. When it was Uncle Papastayo's turn to give a speech, he only said that his agent had given him more provisions only the week before, and he didn't want him to think that he led a greedy people who wasted provisions on dancing. In a statement that drew dark looks from many of the people gathered in the tent, he told the crowd that he had nothing to do with the dance, but he had simply let it be hosted on his property. This was clearly not true, as he himself had given an offering the day before. He warned the men that he would continue to maintain order, and they were not to be wasting bullets in their celebrations. He closed by saying that he was not going to be convinced by another band to seek help from the agent again, as happened that summer, and thanked him for his good will.

After the Pound announced that his dance would shortly come to an end, Papastis and the men of Big Bear's band entered the centre circle for a war dance. Our people drummed around them, the *thum-thum-thum* slowly growing louder. The men were nearly naked, their strong and scarred bodies adorned with paint, their long hair braided with feathers and died-red rawhide. Papastis whirled and weaved among the other dancers, faster and faster as the drums beat louder. As the song climaxed he shot his rifle into the air and one of the dancers fell to the ground. One by one his rifle boomed and the other dancers dropped, symbolizing each of the men he had killed in battle. The noise was deafening. An old man from our band, I don't remember his name, brought out his eldest daughter and she danced on his blanket in his honour. Papastis brought out

a beautiful runner and presented it to the daughter. The people in the crowd cried and shouted as Big Bear's men told stories of Papastis's bravery in battle, the old ones triggered by memories of the wars with the Blackfoot.

I remember the stark difference between my Uncle's presentation to the crowd and Papastis's show of force. It was clear that Big Bear's men didn't come all this way just to show their thanks to Manitou for the recovery of the Pound's daughter. The dance was used as an occasion to share news of things to come for the Nehiyawak. Uncle Tahkoots had been enjoying the perks of our new friendship with the local agent, which had seemed to have blossomed out of thin air. He was quick to tell his new friends the news, including that Big Bear was gathering men to go to Ottawa to bring their issues to the government there, and that he was working with Piapot and an Assiniboine chief. After the dance he had asked one of Walter's sons, a young man barely literate himself, to write a letter to the agent for him. He told the agent that Papastis had brought him tobacco from Big Bear and asked him to join him on the war path out on Sweetgrass's reserve, but he was sending Uncle Papastayo to Battleford with tobacco to tell Big Bear that he would not give his consent to his cause. He told the agent that Uncle Papastayo would tell Big Bear and Piapot to think of their children and their future and that since the peace had come the moniyaw had treated them well and stopped murdering us.

Uncle Tahkoots's and Uncle Papastayo's loyalty to the agents was rewarded that winter. Neither of them shared any more plans with the moniyaw after the thirst dance, whether they had any information to share or not, but it was enough to secure our survival for the time being. In fact, we were surprised by the outbreak of the Resistance in the Goose Moon the next year. One morning, the news of Riel's victory at Duck Lake was brought to us by a Metis runner, one of the many that had been sent across the prairies by Dumont trying to garner support. In fact, the

runner was so fast that we knew about the battle before a telegram bringing the news had even been received at the Fort. Uncle Tahkoots was the one to inform the agent. When the telegram finally did arrive, the line was cut immediately after, which caused the moniyaw at the Fort to break into panic. Rumours spread like wildfire and the agent barricaded himself in the Hudson's Bay Company store in order wait out the imminent battle, refusing to provide support to delegations of Nehiyawak that came to the Fort seeking food and horses from him. All of the moniyaw besieged themselves inside the Fort, fortifying it with volunteers and waiting for thousands of Indians to descend upon them, sending frantic messages for more arms, ammunition, men, and food so they could defend themselves and last through the siege. Much like the last time the agent had called wolf, no one took him seriously. Bloodshed never came to Fort Edmonton, and when the moniyaw felt it was safe to emerge, it was Uncle Papastayo that was rewarded for keeping the peace, not the agent.

That spring, a farming instructor was finally assigned to the reserve. We received four more oxen in reward for keeping order and managed to clear and sow almost seventy acres – twice what we had planted in the past! It was a good harvest. After we brought it in, we travelled deep into Beaver Hills to hunt and trap before Grandfather Winter came. The thirst dance and the improved rations the year before had snapped us out of our decline. Our bodies and spirits grew strong, and it seemed like the hardship before had been nothing more than a waking dream.

I'll always remember how hard we laughed at treaty payment time. Parents used to get payments for each child, and the clerks never asked our names, so we would take turns going with different sets of parents, over and over. I suppose we all looked the same to them. Eventually they would figure out what was going on and they had to mark our faces with a red "X" on our cheek, so they would know that we had been paid for.

The next spring, the Moulting Moon brought another Metis with him. This runner brought news of a great gift from the Mother Chief, called “scrip” – 160 dollars or 160 acres per head of the family, and 220 dollars or 220 acres per child. The gift would allow all the Nehiyawak living on reserves to be free, live outside the chains of the treaty, and go back to being the proud people they once were. The runner spoke passionately about the freedom that his people had fought for, finally being given. All of the resistance was not going to be in vain! He urged us to dream of a future where each family could choose where they settled. Back when Uncle had staked out the reserve, there had been much disagreement over where it would be – many thought that we should have settled further into Beaver Hills to be closer to our traditional hunting grounds. Those people could get their wish, and as for those who wished to stay at Two Hills, the runner assured us that they could remain and own the land as their very own homesteads. Mother thought of being closer to Wetaskiwin, where I was born and where her two babies were buried. All of the restrictions placed on us would suddenly be evaporated. My Uncle had been worked up recently because the agent wouldn’t let him sell any of our cattle or horses. He was enraged by the idea that they were not his to sell, that they belonged to the government. Now we could be free to trade as we once were. We dreamed of what we could do with so much money – we could build a house with two floors, just like the Walters! Instead of relying on the clothes that the agent gave the headmen like my father, we could buy ribbons and beads and shine at the next thirst dance. Remember, we were only given five dollars each per year for our treaties – we thought that much money would surely change everything and last forever.

The following weeks brought a parade of speculators from all across the territories, telling the adults to choose scrip certificates instead of land, which they would be willing to pay cash for. We also received delegates from other bands, who warned us that the certificates were

worth half of what the land was worth, but the speculators assured us that was not the case. They brought gifts of hooch and tobacco, and often stayed long in the camp, playing with the children and complimenting our mothers. We began to look forward to this miracle gift, and by the time the scrip commission arrived at the flats below the Fort, our anticipation was reaching a frenzy.

By then, the flats were like a fairground – everyone from the reserve had forded the river with their packs and erected their tipis around the commission’s tents. Horse races took place throughout the day, and runners changed hands at lightning speed. The surveyors that had visited throughout the spring had all returned, bringing more hooch and beer. It was a happy reunion, and many of the adults got drunk on the free booze. Drums were heard all through the day and night, our hearts as well as our ears were full of song. It seemed like hundreds of tipis had been set up – messengers had been sent to all of those who were hunting and trapping in Beaver Hills, calling them back for the event. Uncle would plead with those who were refusing to go to the commissioner’s tent and accept the discharge. Other Nehiyawak were not so patient and yelled “Slave!” and “you will never be able to own anything!” Usually the combination of pleading and shaming won out – with the exception of the thirst dances, I had never known so many of us to gather like this.

The day after the arrival of the commission, Uncle went to commission’s tent and demanded that our whole band be issued scrip. He didn’t come out for a long time, but we all saw a clerk scramble up the trail to the Fort. We found out later that the clerk had gone to send a telegram to the higher-ups, asking what to do. When he came back, the Inspector, a broad man with a beard like a spade, came out and told us in a booming voice that no more discharges will given that day. Once those who spoke English had translated for us, a roar cried out from the crowd, some of the men even shot their rifles into the air, sending the Inspector scrambling back

into his tent. Uncle went back into the tent too and told the him that we weren't going anywhere until we got our scrip. He even dragged Father Lizee to the Hudson's Bay Company store to dictate a telegram to MacDonald, saying that if the Bear's Hills people got their scrip, why can't we!

Uncle came to father's fire that night and told him that the Inspector said the scrip was only to go to half bloods. Apparently, the Inspector couldn't figure out how to decide if we were half bloods, but it had something to do with whether or not we still lived like Indians. We farm, most of us live in wood cabins in the winter, but we also speak Cree, hunt and fish, and live in lodges in the summer. When father asked how this could be, when by that definition one brother who hunts for his livelihood would not be able to get a discharge, and the other brother who labours for the moniyaw could get one. As well, they had withheld rations until we all picked up spades and plows and otherwise gave up our way of life – how could they now say that despite giving so much up, we still were too Indian? Surely, we at least had lost half of what we once were.

We were true to our word and didn't leave the flats until the Inspector finally received word that my uncles and my father could receive scrip. Every other family was brought into the tent separately and expected to provide witnesses to swear that the head of the family was a half blood. At that point, it was clear that the Inspector didn't know what a half blood was, which meant we *definitely* didn't, but the men were happy to help out other families by swearing it all the same, touching the clerk's pen as he drew an "X" on the paper for them.

Each one emerged after the other, for days on end, until over one hundred of our band members had accepted the scrip, which was over half of us. They would burst out of the tent,

running and dancing into the arms of the speculators who would issue cash for the scrip money certificates. The next morning, the speculators vanished. We never saw them again.

As the leaves began to turn, we called in a great harvest, and bought out half the stores of the Hudson Bay Company. I had the ribbons and glass beads I dreamed of, the adults seemed to be drunk all of the time, my brothers got new rifles, we could afford leather saddles for our horses, and mother took us to the Fort to get photographs of – we even paid the Walter's man to bring us back across the river on the ferry rather than soaking our new stirrups by fording the river.



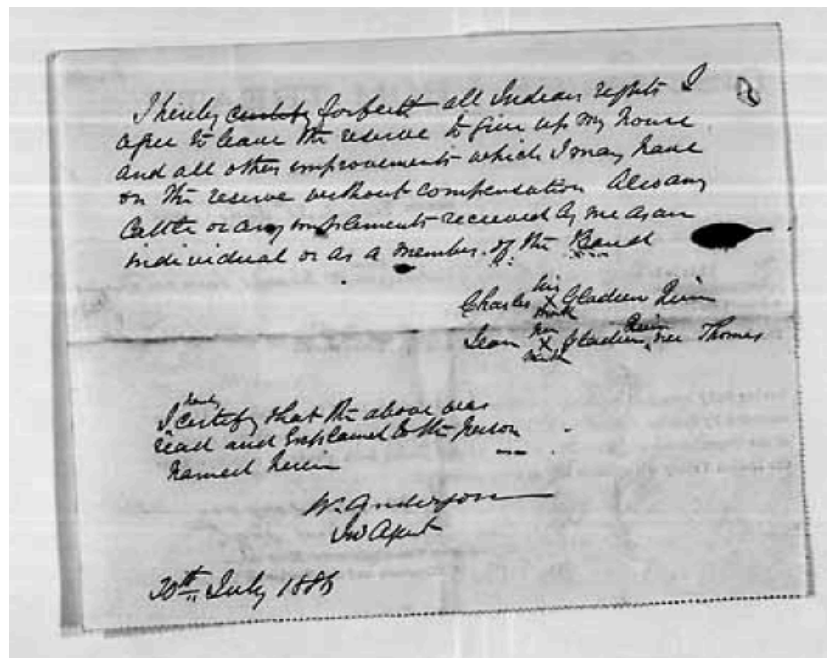
At first we believed that everything was as the surveyors had promised and we were able to stay in our homes at Two Hills, despite warnings from Father Lizée. We thought he was mistaken.

Unfortunately, we soon learned that it was we who were mistaken. Uncle and Father were called to Fort Edmonton during the Frost Moon and told that as soon as it became warm enough to travel, we would have to leave the reserve. They were indignant. There had been some sort of mistake – we had never agreed to leave! Uncle and Father

kept this misunderstanding to themselves – they thought that clearly this would be all cleared up over the summer months, there was no need to worry the members of the band.

As it turned out, there was much need for worry. The agent sent messenger after messenger to us that summer, telling us that we were trespassing and needed to leave immediately. We were not to take any of the farming tools, cattle, or any other ‘government

property' with us, including any of the cabins we built. The messengers came with long lists of the names of those who had received scrip and sought them out, repeating the message. Father began to avoid Uncle's lodge, as there were always angry men gathered there demanding to know what Uncle was going to do about the agent's baseless demands and threats. Eventually, even Uncle had enough, abandoned his crops, and took his family on an extended hunting trip deep into Beaver Hills, perhaps in hope that it would all blow over by the time he got back. He couldn't have been more wrong. Within an hour of his return to Two Hills, the agent came to his cabin to address the matter 'once and for all.' He brought two clerks with him – both of them had been there to witness Uncle's discharge at the Commission tent the year before. He held Uncle's statement up to his face and dared him to deny that he had caused his 'X' mark to be placed on the document.



He read it out loud in front of all of us, the interpreter hastening to keep up to his translation: "I hereby forfeit all Indian rights. I agree to leave the reserve, to free up my house and all other improvements which I may have made on the reserve

WITHOUT compensation, any cattle or any implements received by me as an individual or as a member of the Band."

Through gritted teeth, the agent asked, “did you not sign this paper, sir? Keep in mind, both of these witnesses saw you place your mark upon it.”

After looking intently at the paper, as if to learn to read in a moment through sheer force of will, Uncle agreed that he had indeed placed his mark upon it, but he declared that he had no intention of agreeing to the things that it said. The most catastrophic meaning to be taken from the statement was that he, or anyone who had signed one of these statements, was not entitled to compensation for the work done on the reserve and was not entitled to take with him any of the livestock or tools that he needed to be able to survive elsewhere. Choosing a new place to live within Beaver Hills was one thing, but all of the money from selling the scrip certificate had already been spent and this statement meant that he would have no means to start afresh.

Once they had received his admission the agent and his clerks and interpreter disappeared as quickly as they came – they clearly did not believe that he had not understood the terms of the declaration, or they didn’t care. While initially a general furor from those who had observed the exchange was directed toward Uncle, it was clear that their anger was no match for that of his two wives, who figured that it was they who should have the first opportunity to show him the extent of their anguish. I laid awake that night, curled up with my brothers and sisters under the light horsehair blankets that kept off the summer night chill, and tried to hear my parents whispers over the sound of my siblings’ soft snores and sleepy whimpers. Father explained that he knew he had given up our right to live on the land but had heard that we could purchase a homestead there instead. When mother asked how we were supposed to do that with the scrip money having been spent, father just hung his head and murmured something too quietly for me to hear. It was clear that after having been destitute for so long, even if father did believe that he could use the money towards a homestead, he could not have denied us our short-lived

happiness. I heard him explain that when it became obvious that none of the other heads of family were taking the terms of the discharge seriously, it became easier to believe that we would never have to leave. Unlike uncle's wives, mother didn't guilt him for signing away our rights. I think she knew that the men had been out of their depths. Leaders like uncle and father had been master negotiators, strategic and clever hunters, and brave warriors. They held skills and knowledge of law and justice that belonged to a different landscape. Everyone knew that our people were being driven towards the cliffs edge, just like we once did to the buffalo. And like the moniyaw once did to the buffalo, we might just be driven over it into the void too.

Before dawn broke that morning, I heard uncle quietly let himself into our cabin. He woke my father and they walked to their spot by the riverbank. Uncle told him that he had made a deal with the agent. He would allow us to pack up and move our cabins. We would load everything we could onto ox carts and head into Beaver Hills towards Wetaskiwin. It was the best he could do, he said. We needed to leave as soon as possible, before Grandfather Winter came again.

With all of us working, it took us only one week to pack everything the carts and horses could carry. Much had to be left behind, and we would have to live in our tipis that winter, but part of me looked forward to being far away from our former keepers. There was comfort in knowing that if Manitou had seen us through the horrors of the last ten years, he would see us through this. The day we left Two Hills we made camp at a bend in the Swift Flowing River. As darkness descended, a red glow lit up the sky over Two Hills. Ash fell on our foreheads and shoulders, like an early, hot snowfall, as the cousins we left behind stood and watched their homes burn.